NORMAN TAFL

Strategy and tactics

This booklet gathers what you need to know to play well: how games are won, what really matters on the board, how to open, when to take your king out, the tactical patterns to know and the plans that lead to victory.

1 How games are won
2 What really matters
3 The opening
4 Moving the pair out
5 Tactical patterns
6 Game plans
7 Before every move

1 How games are won

The game is won before the last move. With the threat rule, your opponent must always stop a winning threat. So you win by making a threat that can no longer be stopped: a line to a corner that nothing can close, or a capture of the king that nothing can prevent. Think in unstoppable threats, not in final moves.

Escaping to a corner is the main road. Most games end with a king reaching a corner. Capturing the king is less frequent, but it severely punishes a king that ventures to the wrong place. Blocking every enemy piece is not a realistic way to win.

The escape comes as a surprise. The winning king usually stays inside the board and reaches the edge only at the last moment, on a line nobody can close any more. A king that runs along the edge too early gets its road blocked.

Captures happen in the middle. Away from the edges, the king can be captured in two directions. That is where it is most vulnerable.

The advantage builds up slowly. A pawn won here, a line opened there: games are rarely decided in the opening, but by piling up small advantages.

2 What really matters

Here are the assets of the game, from the most important to the least.

1. **Material.** Every captured pawn brings you clearly closer to victory, and a lead grows stronger as it grows larger. Never give a pawn away for nothing.
2. **The king's freedom.** Each corner your king can reach in two moves is worth almost a pawn. Keep lines open around your king and close those of the enemy king.
3. **The edge.** On an edge, the king can only be captured along the edge: it is the safest place for it and the most dangerous for your opponent. Just beware of the square next to a corner (pattern 5.5).
4. **Threats.** A winning threat forces your opponent to answer and gains you time.
5. **The move.** Every move counts: a waiting move hands the initiative to your opponent. Playing first gives a very slight edge, no more: both sides have their chances.

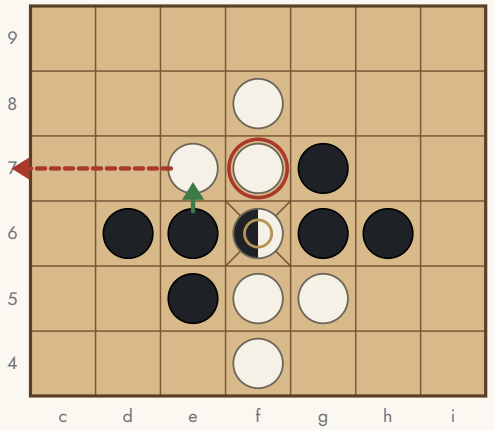
What matters little. Guarding the corners with pawns is almost useless in itself. What matters is being able to bring a piece onto the enemy king's line at the right moment.

3 The opening

The central cross. At the start, the pair is surrounded: black pawns on e6 and g6, white pawns on f5 and f7. These pawns hold each other. Moving one of them without calculation can lose a pawn at once (figure 1).

A flexible opening. No first move decides the game, but some are real mistakes. Every move has a twin, its mirror image by a half-turn of the board, which is worth the same.

- Do not move a pawn of the central cross (e6, g6 for Black; f5, f7 for White), or a pawn supporting it, without checking what it protects.
- Do not move a pawn next to an empty corner: a single enemy pawn can capture it (pattern 5.2).
- Until the pair leaves f6, the game is a pawn battle: win material and prepare lines.



1 A typical first-move mistake by White (Black's first move, away from the centre, is not shown): e7-b7? frees e7, and Black plays e6-e7, capturing f7 between e7 and g7.

Sound first moves

- d1-d3 (or h11-h9)
- d1-c1 (or h11-i11)
- f10-c10 (or f2-i2)
- d11-c11 (or h1-i1)

Outer pawns that prepare lines without weakening anything.

First moves to avoid

- d11-b11 (or h1-j1)
- b10-a10 (or j2-k2)
- e5-e4 (or g7-g8)
- e5-b5 (or g7-j7)

The first two put a pawn next to an empty corner; the other two weaken the central cross.

4 Moving the pair out

This is the main strategic decision of the game: who takes his king out first, and when? The player who leaves takes the initiative but exposes his king. The player who stays on f6 cannot be captured as long as his king does not move.

Neither role is favoured in itself: it all depends on the situation at the moment you leave.

- **With more pawns, leave.** Your lead gives you time to build a line to a corner, and your opponent lacks the pieces to close everything.
- **With equal material, choose your moment.** The chances are balanced: leave when a road opens for your king, not before.
- **With fewer pawns, stay on f6.** Leaving on a gamble usually fails: your king becomes a target and you lack the pieces to protect it.
- **Who wins, and how.** The player who leaves mostly wins by racing to a corner. The player who stays wins more often by capture, when the other king crosses the middle of the board, but he can also leave later and win the race.

> **THE KEY IDEA**
>
> Move the pair out when you are ahead in material, and race to a corner. When behind, keep your king on f6, where it cannot be captured, and watch for the enemy king when it ventures into the middle.

5 Tactical patterns

5.1 · The pincer

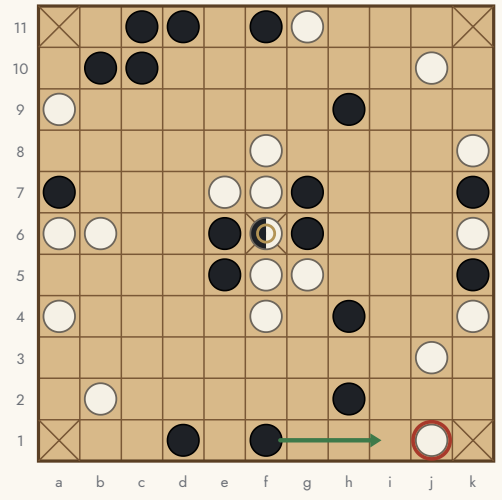
The basic weapon: nearly every capture is made between the arriving pawn and a friendly pawn. A piece is in danger as soon as an enemy pawn can reach the empty square on its other side.

5.2 · The empty anvil

An empty corner or the empty throne counts as a friendly pawn. It is rarer, but it is a classic trap: a pawn standing next to an empty corner falls to a single enemy pawn (figure 2).

5.3 · The double capture

A pawn arriving between two well-supported enemy pieces captures both. Beware of pieces lined up with a gap between them.

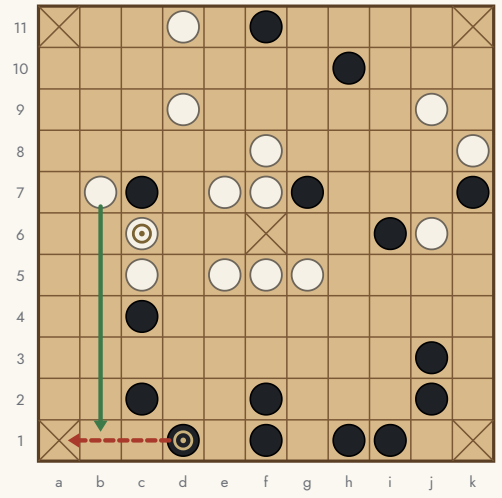


2 f1-i1 captures j1: the empty corner k1 is the other side.

5.4 · Threat and defence

A winning threat cuts your opponent's allowed moves to a handful, often to a single one (figure 3). The defences, from the most common to the rarest: the threatened king steps aside, a piece closes the line, a piece occupies the capture square, or a capture removes the threat.

When attacking, a threat that leaves a single move lets you predict the reply, and so calculate far ahead. Chain forcing threats: each defence you impose is a tempo gained to bring one more piece. **When defending,** look for the defence that also improves your position: a capture, or a piece coming from an area where it was useless.

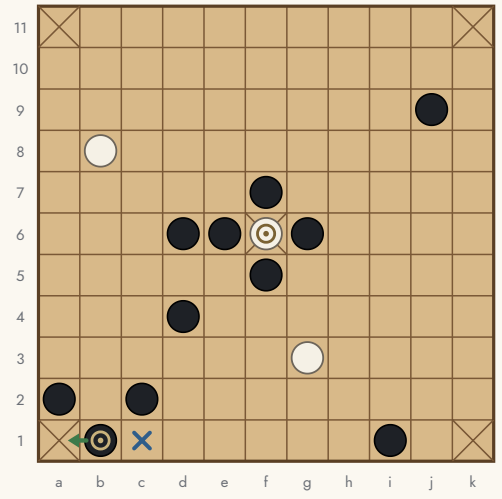


3 The black king threatens a1. White has a single allowed move: b7-b1.

5.5 · The corner as an anvil against the king

A king standing right next to a corner can be captured by a single enemy pawn: the empty corner counts as the other side. Before bringing your king there, check that no enemy pawn can reach the square on its other side (figure 4).

The pattern works both ways. An enemy pawn able to reach the second edge square from a corner (c1 for corner a1) forbids your king from stopping next to that corner (b1): the threat rule makes that move illegal.

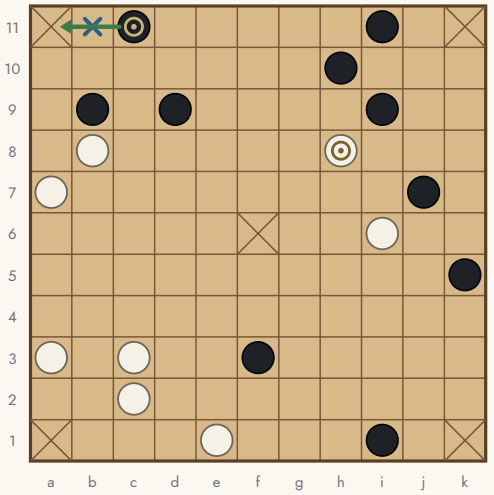


4 The black king on b1 wins with b1-a1. A white pawn on c1 would have captured it against the corner, but none can get there.

5.6 · The unstoppable line

Most winning escapes come from a single threat that nothing can stop: no enemy piece can reach the line between the king and the corner, and the king cannot be captured (figure 5).

The method: for each line between the king and a corner, list the empty squares and, for each one, the enemy pieces able to reach it in one move. If there are none and the king cannot be captured, the line is unstoppable. Do this count for your king, and above all for your opponent's.

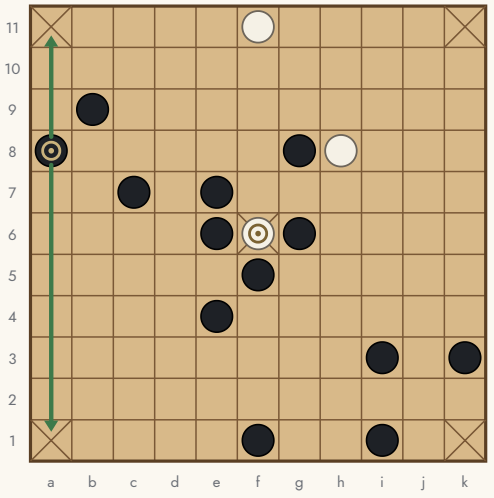


5 The black king threatens a11 through b11, a square no white piece can reach.

5.7 · The corner fork

A king on an edge that is open in both directions threatens two corners at once. Your opponent can close only one line: the game is over (figure 6).

A fork is born on an open edge. Before bringing your king onto an edge, count the enemy pieces on that edge; when defending, keep at least one piece on every edge the enemy king can reach.

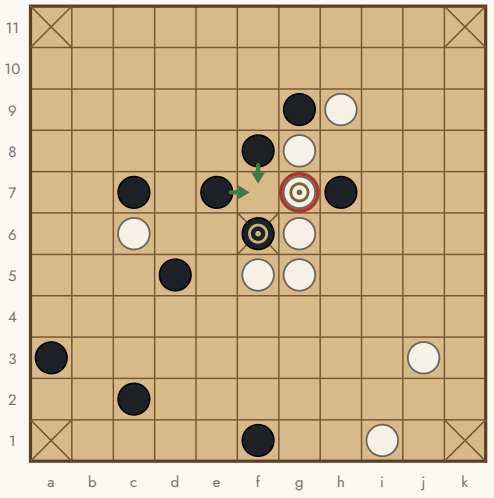


6 The black king on a8 threatens a11 and a1: White can close only one line.

5.8 · The pincer on the king

Most winning captures come from several moves that capture the king, often two pawns aiming at the same square. The other side is usually a friendly pawn, sometimes the empty throne (figure 7).

Away from f6, the king can be captured in two directions. Put a pawn on a square next to the king, then bring two pawns aiming at the opposite square: your opponent must move his king or occupy that square. If he can do neither, the game is won.



7 The white king on g7 has h7 behind it. Both e7-f7 and f8-f7 capture it, and White cannot occupy f7.

6 Game plans

Plan A · The race to a corner

The most frequent winning plan. Move the pair out, keep your king inside, away from pincers, and prepare a line to an edge that your opponent will no longer be able to close. The winning king moves little, and the final strike is sudden. This plan works even with fewer pawns: an unstoppable line is worth more than material. It usually belongs to the player who moved the pair out.

Plan B · Hunting the king

Keep your king on f6, where it cannot be captured, win material, then catch the enemy king as it crosses the middle of the board. The hunter is usually the player who stayed on f6, and he usually wins with more pawns. The key: prepare two pawns aiming at the same square next to the enemy king, with a support on the other side.

Plan C · Suffocation

Immobilising every enemy piece is not a viable plan: with the threat rule, your opponent almost always keeps a free pawn move.

Choosing your plan. When ahead in pawns, leave and race to an edge: the race converts well. When behind, stay on f6 and hunt: the king that leaves first often ends up crossing the middle, where it gets caught.

7 Before every move

1. **Lines to the corners.** Can the enemy king reach an edge, then a corner, in one or two moves? Which pieces could close those lines?
2. **Your king.** Can it be captured next move? Look for the neighbouring squares two enemy pawns can reach.
3. **Your pawns under attack.** A pawn next to an empty corner, or between an enemy piece and a reachable empty square, is in danger.
4. **Your threats.** A threat forces your opponent to defend: he is left with only a few allowed moves. Chain them to gain time.
5. **The pair.** Do you have more pawns? Then leaving may be the right moment. Otherwise keep your king on f6.
6. **Calculate.** A move that looks natural often loses a pawn two or three moves later. The game rewards calculation.

> **IN SHORT**
>
> 1. Every pawn counts.
> 2. Games are almost always won by escaping to a corner: watch the lines, not the corners.
> 3. The winning king stays inside and jumps onto the edge only at the last moment.
> 4. On f6 your king cannot be captured: leave only with an advantage, or when it is safe.
> 5. Next to a corner, a single pawn is enough to capture: your pawns and your king alike.
> 6. A threat leaves your opponent few moves: use it to gain time.
> 7. Two threats at once win the game.